



Electro-Convulsive Therapy (ECT)

Information for consumers,
family and carers



What is ECT and how does it work?

Electroconvulsive Therapy (ECT) is a medical treatment used for a range of mental illnesses including depression, mood disorders and schizophrenia, which have not responded to other medication and psychological therapies.

Modern ECT treatment involves stimulating the brain using a carefully controlled electrical current to induce a seizure. This is done while the patient is unconscious and under a short acting general anaesthetic and muscle relaxant.

How can ECT help?

ECT can be effective in offering some relief and easing of mental illness symptoms. Continued ECT treatment with or without medication management assists in preventing relapse of mental illness symptoms.

Who should consider ECT?

ECT is an effective treatment offered to consumers who experience severe and persistent mental illnesses.

Is ECT safe?

ECT is a very safe treatment option. Medical complications are very low and are comparable to other minor medical procedures involving anaesthesia.



There is no evidence that ECT causes brain damage.

All risks will be considered and discussed with you during your consent for treatment. Please speak with your regular doctor if you have any concerns.

Will ECT affect my memory?

ECT consumers may report a decreased ability to form new memories or recall older memories for a **brief period of time** after treatment. In some rare cases this can last longer. Some ECT consumers will have no memory of the time surrounding treatment or the ECT treatment itself.

Every effort will be made to provide treatment in a way that will reduce the risk of affecting your memory. As part of this, the medical team will be monitoring your memory before, during and after your ECT treatment.

Are there any other side effects?

Other possible side effects may include:

- › mild headaches
- › muscle soreness
- › drowsiness
- › agitation
- › nausea
- › vomiting
- › and very rarely, major cardiac events.

These effects are medically treated if necessary. Feel free to discuss any side effect concerns with your ECT treating team.

How many treatments will I need?

The number of treatments needed varies, as treatment is individualised for each person. Most commonly between 6 and 12 treatments are required for maximum benefit.

On occasion, patients have been known to benefit from extended courses of treatment. For some people, 'maintenance ECT' can be a beneficial option as the most effective way for them to remain well.

Maintenance treatments are individually tailored, and can be provided weekly, fortnightly or monthly as required.

Do I have a choice about ECT treatment?

Voluntary

If you are a voluntary consumer, you will be asked to provide your written consent to the treatment and will have the right to withdraw your consent at any time. Your doctor will discuss the treatment and other options with you.

If you have an identified carer, they have the right to be involved in discussions alongside you about your ECT treatment and are welcome to visit the ECT area.

Involuntary

After discussion with the personal supports/family/guardian and review by the treating consultant psychiatrist, the Mental Health Tribunal may give permission to treat persons involuntarily using ECT.

Occasionally, a consumer may experience mental illness to the severity that their life is at risk, and they cannot or will not give

consent for ECT treatment. In emergency situations, the chief psychiatrist may give permission for ECT treatment.

What happens before treatment?

Prior to your treatment, you will be required to fast from midnight the night before. It will also be necessary to have a blood test, and to check your heart rate, blood pressure and oxygen levels prior to commencing ECT.

What are the stages of treatment?

ECT treatment is usually scheduled from 8am.

You will be assisted to the ECT suite by a nurse from the ward, who will perform a safety check, including giving you a patient ID band to make sure you are prepared for ECT. When you enter the ECT suite, you will meet the treating team who will apply the monitoring leads to your head and chest area.

You will be given anaesthetic via a needle in the back of your hand or arm and an oxygen mask will be placed over your mouth and nose.

As the anaesthetic is given, medical staff recommend that you take deep breaths as this may assist you to feel less anxious about the procedure and feel more relaxed.

Once you are asleep, a small electric current is delivered from the ECT machine for several seconds which results in the seizure. Medical and nursing staff ensure your heart rhythms and physical observations are closely monitored throughout this procedure.



Once the treatment is complete, you will wake from the anaesthesia with an oxygen mask and monitoring in place. Once you have recovered from the anaesthesia, you will be safely returned to the ward.

What happens after treatment?

On return to the ward you will be offered a meal when you feel ready to eat. By early afternoon, most consumers will feel able to return to their usual in-hospital activities or you will be ready to return home.

If I have further questions, who should I ask?

Please ask nursing or medical staff if you require further information or call the ECT Coordinator on 9416 3666.

More information about ECT is available at:

<https://www.beyondblue.org.au>

<https://www.chiefpsychiatrist.wa.gov.au>

<https://www.sane.org/>

Where can I find more on my rights and responsibilities?

ECT consumer rights and responsibilities are outlined under **the WA Mental Health Act, 2014 and The Australian Charter of Health Care Rights** brochure which is available on the ward.

Consumer feedback

Feedback can be provided directly to staff.

Alternatively, provide feedback via:

RPBG.Feedback@health.wa.gov.au

9224 1637

Feedback form in each ward

Please send your feedback forms to:

RPBG.feedback@health.wa.gov.au

OR

RPBG Consumer Engagement Unit

Box X2213 GPO

Perth WA 6847

Add in correct contact details please

Contact the ECT Coordinator Bentley Health Service

F Block, Mills Street, Bentley WA 6102

PO Box 158, Bentley WA 6982

Telephone: (08) 9416 3666

Useful Contacts

24 hours, daily, local call charges -

Mental Health Emergency Response Line: 1300 555 788

Carers WA 1800 242 636

Carers WA Counselling 1800 007 332

Helping Minds (for carers) 08 9427 7100

Lifeline WA 13 11 14

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